Adobe monitors all Flash usage
Every time you use any content that is based on Adobe's Flash, data is stored on your machine and monitored through Local Shared Objects (LSOs) that are similar to cookies. This can be used to track you across Web Sites. You can use browser add-ons to disable LSO.

On your cyberspace trail

Web sites and services extensively log user behaviour. The data is used for advertising, improving content, legal proceedings and sometimes, nefarious activities. We show you how the data is mined, how it looks, and what it is used for

Aditya Madanapalle
aditya.madanapalle@thinkdigit.com

The Internet was conceptualised as an agent for easy sharing of information between machines and by extension, people. From the very beginning, the standards and protocols used as the foundation of the Internet was geared to promote transparency and easy access to everyone. At that point of time, the Internet was not thought of as a medium for electronic businesses, advertising, or social networking. The increased security needed for these services were added later on, force-fitted over the fundamentally open framework of the Internet. This has led to a situation where a significant portion of our activities online are not as safe or secure as they could be. Web 2.0 services use open APIs to allow for third-party content creation. These can be other web services, or desktop software. The implementation of this kind of third-party content is often independent of any of the policies of the site, unmoderated, and possibly unsecure.

Moreover, your activities on-line are valuable information. It serves as a guide for content creators to come up with better, more relevant content, and the advertisers to deliver advertising that you are more likely to respond to. There is a lack of clarity on what kind of data web sites save, but by and large, web sites use a large number of methods to collect as much data as possible. If you have seen prompts on web sites for entering your age, it is not to protect the young from inappropriate content – instead, it's implemented because of laws that prohibit tracking the on-line activities of young people. There are three primary areas of concern – content providers, social networking sites and malware, including worms and Trojans.

Analytics and advertising networks

Web Sites thrive on hits, or visits. To encourage traffic to a Web Site, content providers use something known as analytics. Web analytics use a number of approaches to record, measure and track visitor activity. There are a number of analytic solutions, the most common being Google Analytics. It was one of the first services to offer free Analytics, and the adoption rate in the first few weeks was phenomenal. Analytics show unique hits, page views, repeat visits in a month, the amount of time spent on the web sites, which web pages a visitor spent time on, where the visitor came from and where the visitor is headed to, among other things. All of these may be harmless because of the sheer amount of data that needs to be collected. The data collected is often summarised for whoever is using the analytics service, automatically by the software or web service being used.

The Google Analytics dashboard

The details of what data is collected, and how it is used is hardly ever made public knowledge, and there is no single regulatory authority to oversee analytics. Organisations and networks that provide analytics services often state that the information they collect and use is "non-personally identifiable". This is not entirely true, web analytics providers log IP addresses, and this is enough to identify you as long as the service provider is willing to co-operate. Demographic details, on the income brackets, geographic location, gender and education levels of the visitors are (sometimes mysteriously) available to content providers. This information is used for

GLOSSARY OF WEB TRACKERS

Web Bugs: A web bug is a small, invisible image file (often a 1x1 pixel .gif) hosted on a server, that can be used to track user activity based on who has accessed the file. For example, such an image embedded in a spam mail, can be used to track how many mails have been read, and where.

Beacons: An integration of web bugs and cookies, allowing for even more targeted user information to be remotely retrieved by third parties. The most famous example is the Facebook Beacon service, that was discontinued after legal problems and privacy concerns.

Agents: Highly specific, and often intelligent monitoring tools that can be designed and scripted to monitor almost any kind of input, and can be run over a network, a web host, or a client machine.